

The Tell-Tale Heart

Edgar Allan Poe · 1843

First published: The Pioneer, Jan 1843

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Tell-Tale_Heart (revision 14833580), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 7–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Tell-Tale Heart suggest about guilt and conscience?
- What does The Tell-Tale Heart suggest about the unreliable mind?
- What does The Tell-Tale Heart suggest about obsession?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Tell-Tale Heart	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*guilt and conscience* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Tell-Tale Heart

Author biography

Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown.

Historical and cultural context

Poe wrote in the 1840s, when American magazines were hungry for sensational tales and the new "insanity defense" was making headlines (the 1843 M'Naghten case in Britain set the legal test for madness). He was fascinated by the workings of a guilty mind and by narrators who reveal more than they mean to.

Publication and reception, then and now

"The Tell-Tale Heart" first appeared in The Pioneer, a short-lived Boston magazine edited by James Russell Lowell, in January 1843; Poe was paid about ten dollars. A revised text appeared in the Broadway Journal in 1845.

Then: The story drew little notice in its own day; Poe's reputation rested more on "The Raven" and his criticism.

Now: It is one of the most anthologized American short stories and a standard text for teaching the unreliable narrator, often a student's first encounter with Poe.

Overview (spoiler-free)

A narrator insists he is not mad and sets out to prove it by calmly describing how he decided to kill an old man whose eye disturbed him, and what happened afterward. The story is a confession.

Main themes

- guilt and conscience: the "heart" he hears is the story's central puzzle: the old man's, or his own?
- the unreliable mind: the narrator's every argument for his sanity is evidence against it.
- obsession: a single feature, the eye, takes over his mind.

Why it matters

Students meet unreliable narrators everywhere (in advertising, social media and politics as well as fiction); this story trains them to read a speaker against himself.

Spoilers · teacher only

He kills the old man, dismembers him and hides him under the floorboards; when police call, he is calm until he hears (or imagines) the dead man's heart beating louder and louder, and he confesses.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Tell-Tale Heart: Have you ever tried to convince someone you were calm when you weren't? What gave you away?
Prompt: Before we open The Tell-Tale Heart: Have you ever tried to convince someone you were calm when you weren't? What gave you away?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

unreliable narrator; first-person point of view; dramatic monologue; unity of effect (Poe's idea that every detail should serve one emotional impression).

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown. The world of the book. Poe wrote in the 1840s, when American magazines were hungry for sensational tales and the new "insanity defense" was making headlines (the 1843 M'Naghten case in Britain set the legal test for madness). He was fascinated by the workings of a guilty mind and by narrators who reveal more than they mean to. Publication and reception. "The Tell-Tale Heart" first appeared in The Pioneer, a short-lived Boston magazine edited by James Russell Lowell, in January 1843; Poe was paid about ten dollars. A revised text appeared in the Broadway Journal in 1845. Then: The story drew little notice in its own day; Poe's reputation rested more on "The Raven" and his criticism. Now: It is one of the most anthologized American short stories and a standard text for teaching the unreliable narrator, often a student's first encounter with Poe.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"True!—nervous—very, very dreadfully nervous I had been and am; but why will you say that I am mad" (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 1). The opening: dashes and repetition contradict the claim of calm.

> *True!—nervous—very, very dreadfully nervous I had been and am; but why will you say that I am mad (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: "True!—nervous—very, very dreadfully nervous I had been and am; but why will you say that I am mad" (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 1). The opening: dashes and repetition contradict the claim of calm.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): A narrator insists he is not mad and sets out to prove it by calmly describing how he decided to kill an old man whose eye disturbed him, and what happened afterward. The story is a confession. Themes to track: guilt and conscience: the "heart" he hears is the story's central puzzle: the old man's, or his own? the unreliable mind: the narrator's every argument for his sanity is evidence against it. obsession: a single feature, the eye, takes over his mind.

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Tell-Tale Heart: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Tell-Tale Heart still matter? Students meet unreliable narrators everywhere (in advertising, social media and politics as well as fiction); this story trains them to read a speaker against himself.
Anchor question: Why might The Tell-Tale Heart still be taught today?
Facilitation: Students meet unreliable narrators everywhere (in advertising, social media and politics as well as fiction); this story trains them to read a speaker against himself.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why might Poe have written this story as a confession to a listener? Answer: The listener ("you") lets the narrator argue for his sanity, and his arguments expose his madness; it also implicates the reader as judge.
Exit ticket: Why might Poe have written this story as a confession to a listener?
Answer: The listener ("you") lets the narrator argue for his sanity, and his arguments expose his madness; it also implicates the reader as judge.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Tell-Tale Heart.

Teacher notes · sources: Poe Museum, Richmond, "Poe's Life" (https://poemuseum.org/poes-life/); Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore (texts and publication history) (https://www.eapoe.org/); Poe Society of Baltimore, "The Tell-Tale Heart" texts and publication history (https://www.eapoe.org/works/tales/thhearta.htm)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The ten-dollar payment is the figure given by Poe scholars; treat as approximate.

Lesson 2: The Tell-Tale Heart

Focus: guilt that the mind cannot hide

Content note (murder and dismemberment, described briefly): Sensitive content: Murder and dismemberment, described briefly. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes murder and dismemberment, described briefly.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

An unnamed narrator insists he is sane while describing how the old man's pale blue 'vulture eye' drove him to murder. He spies on the old man for seven nights, kills him on the eighth, dismembers the body and hides it under the floorboards. When police arrive he chats calmly, but a beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart grows louder until he shrieks a confession.

Background: Poe published the story in 1843. Insanity was a live legal question: the 1843 M'Naghten case in Britain set the test for an insanity defense in the same year. Poe's narrators often argue their own case.

Significance: It is one of the most taught examples of an unreliable first-person narrator; every claim of calm reason undercuts itself.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
The narrator keeps telling us he is not mad. Why might someone insist so hard on a point? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to guilt and conscience because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes murder and dismemberment, described briefly.
Prompt: The narrator keeps telling us he is not mad. Why might someone insist so hard on a point?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to guilt and conscience because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: dismembered — cut a body into pieces; suavity — smooth, polished politeness; dissemble — to hide one's true feelings; dissimulation — hiding one's true feelings or intentions; uncontrollable — difficult to solve or alleviate.
Words: dismembered: cut a body into pieces · suavity: smooth, polished politeness · dissemble: to hide one's true feelings · dissimulation: hiding one's true feelings or intentions · uncontrollable: difficult to solve or alleviate

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Poe published the story in 1843. Insanity was a live legal question: the 1843 M'Naghten case in Britain set the test for an insanity defense in the same year. Poe's narrators often argue their own case. It is one of the most taught examples of an unreliable first-person narrator; every claim of calm reason undercuts itself. Point of view: A first-person narrator speaks to an unnamed "you," perhaps a judge, doctor or jailer. His insistence on his sanity is the story's main irony: the more carefully he argues, the less we believe him. Irony: Dramatic irony runs through the whole: he says the police "chatted pleasantly" while he grows frantic; he boasts of his "wisdom" and caution while describing a murder. Imagery: The "vulture" eye, the lantern's single ray, the heartbeat like "a watch enveloped in cotton": sound and sight narrowed to a point, as his mind is. Watch for the eye: the "Evil Eye" stands for being seen and judged; the narrator kills to escape a gaze.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult" (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2). He admits there is no motive, which undermines his claim to be reasonable. That is point of view at work: A first-person narrator speaks to an unnamed "you," perhaps a judge, doctor or jailer. His insistence on his sanity is the story's main irony: the more carefully he argues, the less we believe him.

> *I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult* *(The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult" (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2). He admits there is no motive, which undermines his claim to be reasonable. That is point of view at work: A first-person narrator speaks to an unnamed "you," perhaps a judge, doctor or jailer. His insistence on his sanity is the story's main irony: the more carefully he argues, the less we believe him.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: "Vulture" makes the eye predatory; "film" makes it half-blind and inhuman. The narrator turns a feature into a monster, showing obsession and an unreliable mind. Ask: How does this line connect to guilt and conscience? Expected: The heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. (The obsession; the vulture suggests death and preying.)

> *One of his eyes resembled that of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a film over it (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: "Vulture" makes the eye predatory; "film" makes it half-blind and inhuman. The narrator turns a feature into a monster, showing obsession and an unreliable mind.
Ask: How does this line connect to guilt and conscience?
Expected answer: The heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. (The obsession; the vulture suggests death and preying.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for point of view, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about guilt that the mind cannot hide? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Tell-Tale Heart develops the idea of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. When the text says “I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2), it shows this directly. He says "I loved the old man. He had never wronged me," so the murder has no rational motive, yet he calls his own planning "wisdom"; the gap between his reasons and his act exposes him.
Task: Annotate the story for point of view, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about guilt that the mind cannot hide? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Tell-Tale Heart develops the idea of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. When the text says “I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2), it shows this directly. He says "I loved the old man. He had never wronged me," so the murder has no rational motive, yet he calls his own planning "wisdom"; the gap between his reasons and his act exposes him.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: The narrator keeps telling us he is not mad. Why might someone insist so hard on a point? Ask: whose heart does he hear? Have students defend one reading with two quotations. Content note: murder and dismemberment, described without much gore. Keep focus on how Poe builds suspense.
Anchor question: The narrator keeps telling us he is not mad. Why might someone insist so hard on a point?
Facilitation: Ask: whose heart does he hear? Have students defend one reading with two quotations. · Content note: murder and dismemberment, described without much gore. Keep focus on how Poe builds suspense.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about guilt that the mind cannot hide? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. ("I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult", The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about guilt that the mind cannot hide? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. ("I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult", The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes guilt that the mind cannot hide. Key takeaway: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Point of view:** A first-person narrator speaks to an unnamed "you," perhaps a judge, doctor or jailer. His insistence on his sanity is the story's main irony: the more carefully he argues, the less we believe him.
- **Irony:** Dramatic irony runs through the whole: he says the police "chatted pleasantly" while he grows frantic; he boasts of his "wisdom" and caution while describing a murder.
- **Imagery:** The "vulture" eye, the lantern's single ray, the heartbeat like "a watch enveloped in cotton": sound and sight narrowed to a point, as his mind is.

Themes and how they develop

- **guilt and conscience:** the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation.

Symbols and motifs

- **the eye:** the "Evil Eye" stands for being seen and judged; the narrator kills to escape a gaze.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2) He admits there is no motive, which undermines his claim to be reasonable.
- “One of his eyes resembled that of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a film over it” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2) The obsession; the vulture suggests death and preying.
- “it is the beating of his hideous heart” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 18) The final confession; "hideous" transfers his horror to the sound.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness.
Evidence: “I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2)
Reasoning: He says "I loved the old man. He had never wronged me," so the murder has no rational motive, yet he calls his own planning "wisdom"; the gap between his reasons and his act exposes him.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
dismembered (verb)	cut a body into pieces	*First of all I dismembered the corpse.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
suavity (noun)	smooth, polished politeness	*There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dissemble (verb)	to hide one's true feelings	*"Villains!" I shrieked, "dissemble no more!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dissimulation (noun)	hiding one's true feelings or intentions	*You should have seen how wisely I proceeded—with what caution—with what foresight—with what dissimulation I went to work!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
uncontrollable (adjective)	difficult to solve or alleviate	*And now at the dead hour of the night, amid the dreadful silence of that old house, so strange a noise as this excited me to uncontrollable terror.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

strides (noun)	a step in walking or running	*I paced the floor to and fro with heavy strides, as if excited to fury by the observations of the men—but the noise steadily increased.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
watches (noun)	a small portable timepiece	*He was still sitting up in the bed, listening;—just as I have done, night after night, hearkening to the death watches in the wall.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
premises (noun)	assumptions an argument is based on	*A shriek had been heard by a neighbor during the night; suspicion of foul play had been aroused; information had been lodged at the police office, and they (the officers) had been deputed to search the premises.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
tolerable (adjective)	capable of being borne or endured	*Anything was more tolerable than this derision!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. The narrator keeps telling us he is not mad. Why might someone insist so hard on a point?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with guilt and conscience?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does the narrator say drove him to kill the old man? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The old man's pale 'vulture' eye
2. How many nights does the narrator watch the old man before acting? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Seven, killing him on the eighth
3. Where does the narrator hide the body? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Under the floorboards of the chamber
4. Why do the police come to the house? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A neighbor heard a shriek in the night
5. What makes the narrator confess? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Tell-Tale Heart” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: An unnamed narrator insists he is sane while describing how the old man's pale blue 'vulture eye' drove him to murder. He spies on the old man for seven nights, kills him on the eighth,

dismembers the body and hides it under the floorboards. When police arrive he chats calmly, but a beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart grows louder until he shrieks a confession.

7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Tell-Tale Heart”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Tell-Tale Heart” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “First of all I dismembered the corpse.” What does “dismembered” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: dismembered: cut a body into pieces.
10. Reread: “There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.” What does “suavity” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: suavity: smooth, polished politeness.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Tell-Tale Heart” suggest about guilt that the mind cannot hide? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: It is one of the most taught examples of an unreliable first-person narrator; every claim of calm reason undercuts itself.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the irony in this story shape what we understand about guilt that the mind cannot hide? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): He admits there is no motive, which undermines his claim to be reasonable. On irony: Dramatic irony runs through the whole: he says the police "chatted pleasantly" while he grows frantic; he boasts of his "wisdom" and caution while describing a murder. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “I kept quite still and said nothing.”, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Tell-Tale Heart”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An unnamed narrator insists he is sane while describing how the old man's pale blue 'vulture eye' drove him to murder. He spies on the old man for seven nights, kills him on the eighth, dismembers the body and hides it under the floorboards. When police arrive he chats calmly, but a beating sound…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Tell-Tale Heart” set up that the rest of The Tell-Tale Heart will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “One of his eyes resembled that of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a

film over it" (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): The obsession; the vulture suggests death and preying. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: "it is the beating of his hideous heart" (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 18): The final confession; "hideous" transfers his horror to the sound. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: "The narrator keeps telling us he is not mad. Why might someone insist so hard on a point?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.

9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with guilt and conscience? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: "I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult" (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): He admits there is no motive, which undermines his claim to be reasonable. On imagery: The "vulture" eye, the lantern's single ray, the heartbeat like "a watch enveloped in cotton": sound and sight narrowed to a point, as his mind is. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Background: Poe published the story in 1843. Insanity was a live legal question: the 1843 M'Naghten case in Britain set the test for an insanity defense in the same year. Poe's narrators often argue their own case. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: "One of his eyes resembled that of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a film over it" (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): The obsession; the vulture suggests death and preying. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "It is one of the most taught examples of an unreliable first-person narrator; every claim of calm reason undercuts itself." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what

reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “it is the beating of his hideous heart” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 18): The final confession; "hideous" transfers his horror to the sound. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): He admits there is no motive, which undermines his claim to be reasonable. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of “The Tell-Tale Heart” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about guilt that the mind cannot hide? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “One of his eyes resembled that of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a film over it” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): The obsession; the vulture suggests death and preying. On point of view: A first-person narrator speaks to an unnamed "you," perhaps a judge, doctor or jailer. His insistence on his sanity is the story's main irony: the more carefully he argues, the less we believe him. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Tell-Tale Heart”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “it is the beating of his hideous heart” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 18): The final confession; "hideous" transfers his horror to the sound. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to the unreliable mind: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): He admits there is no motive, which undermines his claim to be reasonable. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and

evidence.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “One of his eyes resembled that of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a film over it” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): The obsession; the vulture suggests death and preying. On point of view: A first-person narrator speaks to an unnamed "you," perhaps a judge, doctor or jailer. His insistence on his sanity is the story's main irony: the more carefully he argues, the less we believe him. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Tell-Tale Heart” treats guilt that the mind cannot hide with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Tell-Tale Heart see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “it is the beating of his hideous heart” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 18): The final confession; "hideous" transfers his horror to the sound. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve guilt and conscience? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): He admits there is no motive, which undermines his claim to be reasonable. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about guilt that the mind cannot hide? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “One of his eyes resembled that of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a film over it” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 2): The obsession; the vulture suggests death and preying. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's attempt to prove his sanity is what reveals his madness. Useful evidence: “it is the beating of his hideous heart” (The Tell-Tale Heart, paragraph 18): The final confession; "hideous" transfers his horror to the sound. Theme link: the heartbeat he hears can be read as the old man's (supernatural) or his own (psychological guilt); either way, conscience defeats his calculation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz

1. What does the narrator say drove him to kill the old man?
   A. The old man's pale 'vulture' eye
   B. A quarrel over rent
   C. An insult from the old man
   D. The old man's money
2. How many nights does the narrator watch the old man before acting?
   A. Thirty
   B. Three
   C. One
   D. Seven, killing him on the eighth
3. Where does the narrator hide the body?
   A. In the garden
   B. Under the floorboards of the chamber
   C. In the river
   D. In the cellar wall
4. Why do the police come to the house?
   A. A neighbor heard a shriek in the night
   B. The old man's son reports him missing
   C. They are searching for a thief
   D. The narrator calls them
5. What makes the narrator confess?
   A. The police find the body
   B. He finds the old man's will
   C. A witness accuses him
   D. A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart
6. In the line “First of all I dismembered the corpse.”, what does “dismembered” most nearly mean?
   A. to hide one's true feelings
   B. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
   C. cut a body into pieces
   D. smooth, polished politeness

7. In the line “There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.”, what does “suavity” most nearly mean?
   A. cut a body into pieces
   B. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
   C. to hide one's true feelings
   D. smooth, polished politeness

Answer key: 1. A (The old man's pale 'vulture' eye); 2. D (Seven, killing him on the eighth); 3. B (Under the floorboards of the chamber); 4. A (A neighbor heard a shriek in the night); 5. D (A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart); 6. C (cut a body into pieces); 7. D (smooth, polished politeness)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Tell-Tale Heart,” how does Poe show guilt that the mind cannot hide? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): In The Tell-Tale Heart, how does Poe develop the idea of guilt that the mind cannot hide? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Tell-Tale Heart develops the idea of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of The Tell-Tale Heart (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what The Tell-Tale Heart suggests about guilt that the mind cannot hide. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses point of view in The Tell-Tale Heart to complicate the reader's understanding of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Tell-Tale Heart within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of guilt that the mind

cannot hide responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Tell-Tale Heart alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of guilt that the mind cannot hide follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Tell-Tale Heart and its treatment of guilt that the mind cannot hide. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Tell-Tale Heart as evidence for a larger claim about guilt that the mind cannot hide in The Tell-Tale Heart. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Tell-Tale Heart as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of guilt that the mind cannot hide. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Tell-Tale Heart.

SAT-style questions

1. *"Villains!" I shrieked, "dissemble no more!*

   As used in the text, what does the word “dissemble” most nearly mean?

   A. to hide one's true feelings

   B. capable of being borne or endured

   C. assumptions an argument is based on

   D. a small portable timepiece

2. *I kept quite still and said nothing. For a whole hour I did not move a muscle, and in the mean time I did not hear him lie down. He was still sitting up in the bed, listening;—just as I have done, night after night, hearkening to the death watches in the wall.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Tell-Tale Heart”?

   A. Guilt that the mind cannot hide

   B. Revenge carried out with perfect control

   C. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

   D. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

SAT key: 1. A (to hide one's true feelings); 2. A (Guilt that the mind cannot hide)

Whole-book test

The Tell-Tale Heart: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What does the narrator say drove him to kill the old man?
   A. The old man's pale 'vulture' eye
   B. A quarrel over rent
   C. An insult from the old man
   D. The old man's money
2. How many nights does the narrator watch the old man before acting?
   A. Thirty
   B. Three
   C. One
   D. Seven, killing him on the eighth
3. Where does the narrator hide the body?
   A. In the garden
   B. Under the floorboards of the chamber
   C. In the river
   D. In the cellar wall
4. Why do the police come to the house?
   A. A neighbor heard a shriek in the night
   B. The old man's son reports him missing
   C. They are searching for a thief
   D. The narrator calls them
5. What makes the narrator confess?
   A. The police find the body
   B. He finds the old man's will
   C. A witness accuses him
   D. A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart
6. In the line “First of all I dismembered the corpse.”, what does “dismembered” most nearly mean?
   A. to hide one's true feelings
   B. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
   C. cut a body into pieces
   D. smooth, polished politeness

7. In the line “There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.”, what does “suavity” most nearly mean?
   A. cut a body into pieces
   B. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
   C. to hide one's true feelings
   D. smooth, polished politeness
8. As used in the story (“First of all I dismembered the corpse.”), what does “dismembered” mean?
   A. cut a body into pieces
   B. difficult to solve or alleviate
   C. assumptions an argument is based on
   D. to hide one's true feelings
9. As used in the story (“There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police.”), what does “suavity” mean?
   A. a step in walking or running
   B. smooth, polished politeness
   C. capable of being borne or endured
   D. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
10. As used in the story (“"Villains!" I shrieked, "dissemble no more!”), what does “dissemble” mean?
    A. a small portable timepiece
    B. cut a body into pieces
    C. to hide one's true feelings
    D. difficult to solve or alleviate
11. As used in the story (“You should have seen how wisely I proceeded—with what caution—with what foresight—with what dissimulation I went to work!”), what does “dissimulation” mean?
    A. assumptions an argument is based on
    B. smooth, polished politeness
    C. a step in walking or running
    D. hiding one's true feelings or intentions
12. As used in the story (“And now at the dead hour of the night, amid the dreadful silence of that old house, so strange a noise as this excited me to uncontrollable ”), what does “uncontrollable” mean?
    A. difficult to solve or alleviate
    B. capable of being borne or endured
    C. to hide one's true feelings
    D. a small portable timepiece

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how guilt and conscience develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how the unreliable mind develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how obsession develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (guilt and conscience, the unreliable mind, obsession) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (The old man's pale 'vulture' eye); 2. D (Seven, killing him on the eighth); 3. B (Under the floorboards of the chamber); 4. A (A neighbor heard a shriek in the night); 5. D (A beating sound he believes is the dead man's heart); 6. C (cut a body into pieces); 7. D (smooth, polished politeness); 8. A (cut a body into pieces); 9. B (smooth, polished politeness); 10. C (to hide one's true feelings); 11. D (hiding one's true feelings or intentions); 12. A (difficult to solve or alleviate)

Essay assignments

Essay: Guilt and conscience

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Tell-Tale Heart teaches about guilt and conscience. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops guilt and conscience across The Tell-Tale Heart. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Tell-Tale Heart (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of guilt and conscience. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Tell-Tale Heart (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of guilt and conscience, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Tell-Tale Heart's treatment of guilt and conscience in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging at least four

scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on guilt and conscience in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The unreliable mind

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Tell-Tale Heart teaches about the unreliable mind. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the unreliable mind across The Tell-Tale Heart. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Tell-Tale Heart (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the unreliable mind. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Tell-Tale Heart (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the unreliable mind, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Tell-Tale Heart's treatment of the unreliable mind in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the unreliable mind in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Obsession

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Tell-Tale Heart teaches about obsession. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops obsession across The Tell-Tale Heart. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Tell-Tale Heart (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of obsession. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Tell-Tale Heart (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of obsession, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Tell-Tale Heart's treatment of obsession in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on obsession in The Tell-Tale Heart, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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